Same service, different price

Service: Blood test, comprehensive group of blood chemicals

Product line: Commercial

Min Rate	Median Rate	Max Rate	Spread
$8	$53	$360	42.6x

Payer	Aurora St. Luke's Medical Center	Bellin Memorial Hospital	HSHS St. Vincent Hospital	Marshfield Medical Center	University Hospital
Three Rivers Provider Network		$59		$191	
MultiPlan	$221	$53	$74	$189	$326
Group Health Cooperative of Eau Claire				$175	$303
Aetna	$260		$70		$287
The Alliance				$155	$197
Trilogy	$37	$50	$73	$187	$212
HealthSmart		$53	$74	$193	$334
Chorus Community Health Plan		$66			$303
Security Health Plan		$50	$65	$64	$223
First Health (Aetna)		$56	$97	$191	
Cigna	$266	$47	$71	$189	$227
WPS Health Insurance	$36	$48	$61	$194	$276
Health Payment Systems	$26	$48			$232
Aspirus Health Plan		$44			$257
HealthPartners	$136	$35		$191	$231
Network Health		$31	$77		
Common Ground Healthcare Cooperative	$23	$29			
Anthem Blue Cross Blue Shield	$140	$29	$30	$63	$165
Quartz	$29		$11		
UnitedHealthcare	$8	$28	$13	$37	$237
Total	**$36**	**$46**	**$21**	**$181**	**$239**

Which hospitals cost more?

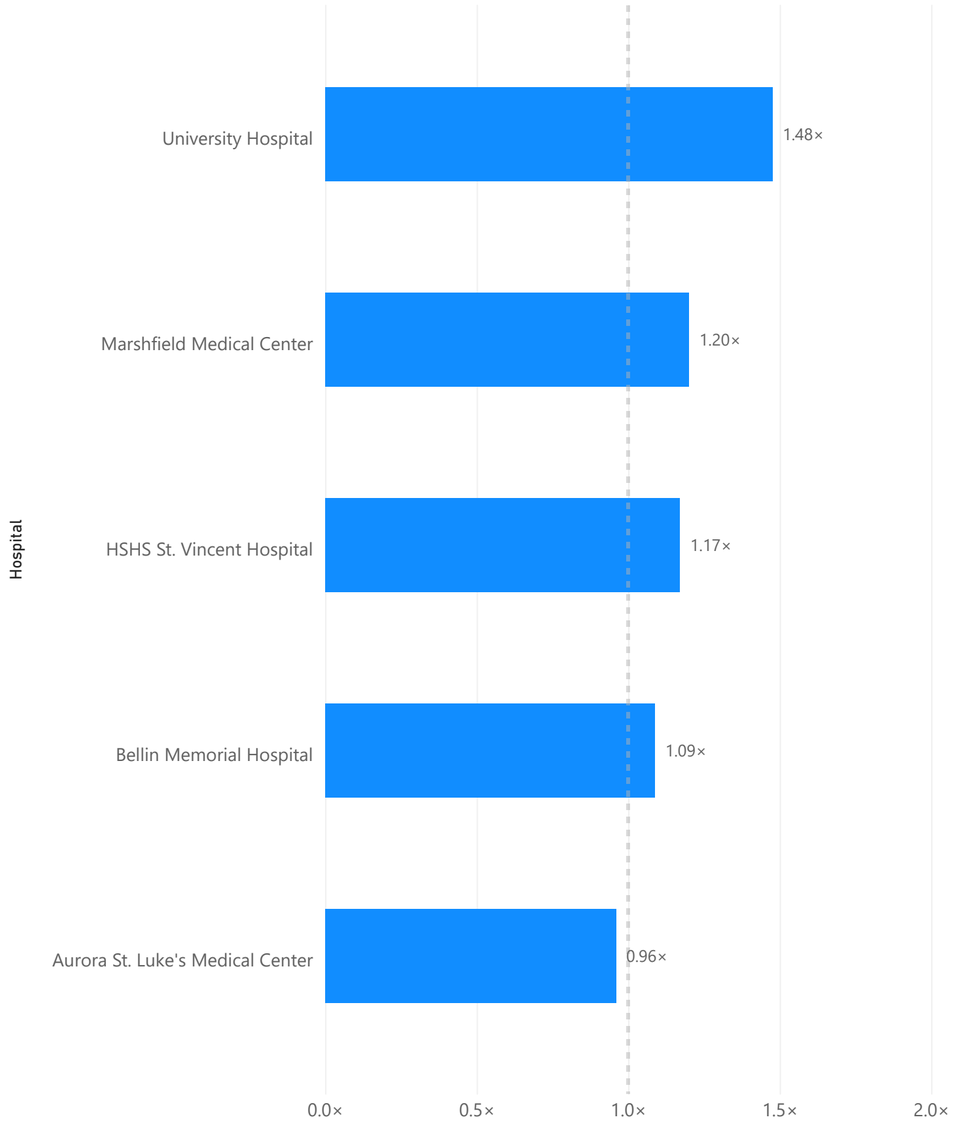
Price index = hospital's commercial rate ÷ typical rate for that service across all 5 hospitals. 1.00× = typical.

category

All

Overall price index (avg across services)

Avg Price Index by Hospital



Service	Aurora St. Luke's Medical Center	Bellin Memorial Hospital	HSHS St. Vincent Hospital	Marshfield Medical Center	University Hospital
Abdominal ultrasound of pregnant uterus (greater or equal to 14 weeks 0 days) single or first fetus	0.85×	0.94×	0.94×		1.25×
Automated urinalysis test	0.39×	0.48×		1.17×	1.26×
Basic metabolic panel	0.60×	0.90×	0.29×	2.96×	3.85×
Biopsy of large bowel using an endoscope	1.08×	1.26×		0.45×	1.23×
Biopsy of prostate gland	1.35×	1.16×	1.49×	0.19×	
Biopsy of the esophagus, stomach, and/or upper small bowel using an endoscope	1.20×	0.97×		0.84×	1.03×
Blood test, clotting time	0.62×	0.79×	1.47×	2.07×	1.49×
Blood test, comprehensive group of blood chemicals	0.66×	0.89×	0.39×	3.24×	4.59×
Blood test, lipids (cholesterol and triglycerides)	0.66×	0.88×	1.42×	2.85×	2.72×
Blood test, thyroid stimulating hormone (TSH)	0.47×	0.72×	1.18×	1.63×	1.53×
Cardiac valve and other major cardiothoracic procedures with cardiac catheterization with major complications or comorbidities	1.07×	0.78×		1.09×	1.06×
Cervical spinal fusion without comorbid conditions (CC) or major comorbid conditions or complications (MCC)	1.05×	0.78×		1.07×	1.06×
Coagulation assessment blood test	0.62×	0.82×	1.62×	1.82×	1.86×
Complete blood cell count, with differential white blood cells, automated	0.53×	0.71×	1.29×	2.48×	1.76×
Complete blood count, automated	0.54×	0.73×	1.18×	2.47×	1.46×
CT scan of abdomen and pelvis with contrast	0.39×	0.45×	1.10×		1.35×
CT scan, head or brain, without contrast	0.95×	0.32×	1.11×		1.20×
CT scan, pelvis, with contrast	0.66×	0.55×	0.95×	1.02×	1.16×
Diagnostic examination of esophagus, stomach, and/or upper small bowel using an endoscope	1.19×	1.02×		0.84×	0.83×

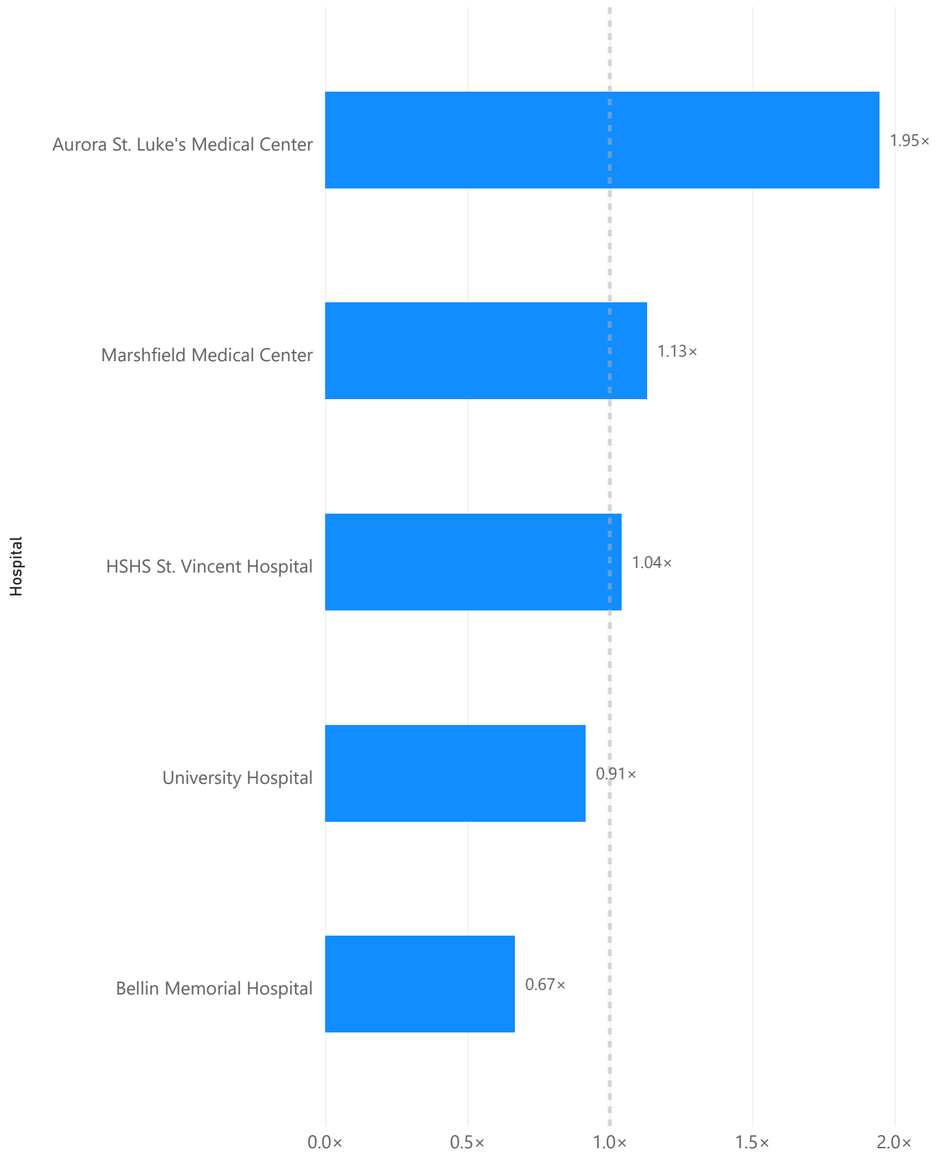
Is paying cash cheaper than insurance?

Cash price ÷ commercial insurers' median rate for the same service. Below 1.00× = cash is cheaper.

Category

All

Cash price ÷ commercial rate (avg across services)



Service	Aurora St. Luke's Medical Center	Bellin Memorial Hospital	HSHS St. Vincent Hospital	Marshfield Medical Center	University Hospital
Abdominal ultrasound of pregnant uterus (greater or equal to 14 weeks 0 days) single or first fetus	1.19×	0.67×	0.94×		0.94×
Automated urinalysis test	2.30×	0.60×		1.48×	0.93×
Basic metabolic panel	2.69×	0.63×	3.91×	1.12×	0.94×
Biopsy of large bowel using an endoscope		0.64×		1.00×	0.83×
Biopsy of prostate gland	0.44×		0.78×	1.01×	
Biopsy of the esophagus, stomach, and/or upper small bowel using an endoscope		0.60×			0.94×
Blood test, clotting time	2.20×	0.69×	0.94×	1.12×	0.90×
Blood test, comprehensive group of blood chemicals	4.50×	0.65×	3.30×	1.12×	0.94×
Blood test, lipids (cholesterol and triglycerides)	2.45×	0.66×	0.94×	1.12×	0.94×
Blood test, thyroid stimulating hormone (TSH)	1.40×	0.71×	0.94×	1.12×	0.94×
Coagulation assessment blood test	2.51×	0.66×	0.95×	1.12×	0.86×
Complete blood cell count, with differential white blood cells, automated	2.72×	0.65×	0.94×	1.12×	0.94×
Complete blood count, automated	2.33×	0.64×	0.94×	1.12×	0.94×
CT scan of abdomen and pelvis with contrast	2.73×	0.95×	0.94×		0.94×
CT scan, head or brain, without contrast	1.28×	1.03×	0.94×		0.91×
CT scan, pelvis, with contrast	1.37×	0.99×	0.94×	1.09×	0.94×
Diagnostic examination of esophagus, stomach, and/or upper small bowel using an endoscope		0.61×			0.94×
Diagnostic examination of large bowel using an endoscope		0.54×		1.00×	0.94×
Family psychotherapy, including patient, 50 min	0.77×	0.54×	0.92×	1.08×	0.94×
Family psychotherapy, not including patient, 50 min	0.77×	0.62×	0.92×	1.08×	0.94×
Group psychotherapy	0.77×	0.58×	0.78×	1.07×	

About the data

Source: Machine-readable standard-charge files that hospitals must publish under the CMS Hospital Price Transparency rule (45 CFR 180), all in CMS template v3.0.

Hospitals (file date):

- Aurora St. Luke's Medical Center, Milwaukee (Nov 21, 2025)
- Bellin Memorial Hospital, Green Bay (Jun 27, 2026)
- HSHS St. Vincent Hospital, Green Bay (Mar 24, 2026)
- Marshfield Medical Center, Marshfield (Feb 20, 2026)
- University Hospital (UW Health), Madison (Apr 1, 2026)

Services: The 70 CMS-specified shoppable services (CY2020 OPPS final rule, Table 3), matched by CPT code or MS-DRG.

Method:

- Facility rates only; rows with modifiers excluded.
- Payer-specific rates in dollars only (percent-of-charge rates excluded).
- 159 raw payer names grouped into 66 parent payers.
- Medians, not volume-weighted: the files say what was negotiated, not how often it's paid.

Limitations: Files are published on different dates, and hospitals label codes inconsistently (some internal codes are tagged as HCPCS and were excluded). Product line (commercial, Medicare Advantage, Medicaid) is inferred from payer and plan names.

Pipeline: Python + DuckDB: download → load → data-quality checks → SQL model → Parquet → Power BI. Code: github.com/heathlanders/wi-hospital-prices